

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 556

By Walley

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Patricia Lee Newton of Nashville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Patricia Lee Newton of Nashville; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for her fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born in Tulsa, Oklahoma, in 1948, Patricia Lee Newton was the daughter and eldest child of Dr. Kenneth Newton and Mary Rick Newton; she arrived while her father was attending the University of Tulsa on the GI bill; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton's parents met while working on the Manhattan Project in Oak Ridge, and the family returned to Tennessee and settled in Knoxville after Mr. Newton's graduation from the University of Tulsa. He earned a Ph.D. from the University of Tennessee, Knoxville and served as a professor; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Newton graduated from Knoxville Catholic High School in 1966 and received her Bachelor of Science degree in History from the University of Tennessee, Knoxville in 1971; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton married Steve Rechichar, and they became the devoted parents of Rachel Rechichar Newton; the couple divorced in 1976, and Rachel lived with her mother most of the time; while working full time as an attorney, Patricia Newton spared no effort or expense in making sure her daughter remained her top priority; and

WHEREAS, a trailblazer for women in the legal profession, Patricia Newton graduated from the University of Tennessee Law School in 1975, alongside very few other women in her

class, and was admitted to the Tennessee Bar that same year, working with the law firm of Sid Gilreath in Knoxville; and

WHEREAS, in 1978, Patricia Newton and her daughter moved to Nashville, where Ms. Newton became an Assistant Public Defender for Metro Nashville before launching her distinguished public service career with the State of Tennessee under the Governor Lamar Alexander administration in 1981; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton began her service with the State of Tennessee as a lawyer in the Office of the General Counsel at the Tennessee Department of Health, eventually working her way up to Managing Attorney in that office; and

WHEREAS, during her tenure at the Tennessee Department of Health, she was part of the legal team involved in the transition to TennCare, Tennessee's Medicaid program, becoming one of the first attorneys to work on TennCare issues on behalf of families and children, ensuring their rights to due process; and

WHEREAS, in 1995, Ms. Newton joined the Office of the General Counsel of the Tennessee Department of Finance and Administration as an attorney, and from 1997 until 1999, she served as Deputy General Counsel in the Office of the General Counsel of the Tennessee Department of Children's Services; and

WHEREAS, in 1999, she was appointed by Governor Don Sundquist to be Assistant Commissioner for the TennCare Oversight Division and was later appointed as Acting Deputy Commissioner of the Tennessee Department of Commerce and Insurance; and

WHEREAS, from 2003 to 2005, she served as the Deputy to the Assistant Commissioner in the Bureau of TennCare in the Tennessee Department of Finance and Administration, and from 2005 to 2007, she served as the Managing Attorney for the Operations of the Bureau of TennCare; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton loved her career in public service and never retired, even in the face of illness. At the time of her passing, she was serving as Compliance Manager of the TennCare Oversight Division of the Tennessee Department of Commerce and Insurance, a role she had held since 2007; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton and David H. Lillard, Jr., the Treasurer of the State of Tennessee, were joined in holy matrimony and enjoyed almost twenty-five years of marriage, building a wonderful life together; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Newton was deeply devoted to her family, and she always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Newton is survived by her devoted husband, David H. Lillard, Jr., and her beloved daughter, Rachel Newton; and

WHEREAS, she will be sadly mourned but fondly remembered by her brother, Ross Newton; her sisters, Michele (Randy) Neal and Maureen Newton; her sister-in-law, Glenda Newton; her stepchildren and their significant others, Brooke Lillard and her fiancé, Terry Sween, and Scott Lillard and his wife, Julie Carter; her sister-in-law, Robin Lillard Bates; her nieces and nephews, Kelly (Chris) Douglass, Jason Newton, Jennifer Newton Greer, Alex Newton, William Newton, and Julia Newton; and

WHEREAS, in addition to her parents, Ms. Newton was preceded in death by her brothers, Rick and Kevin; and

WHEREAS, Patricia Newton leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all her chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Patricia Lee Newton, reflecting fondly upon her impeccable character and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Ms. Newton.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.